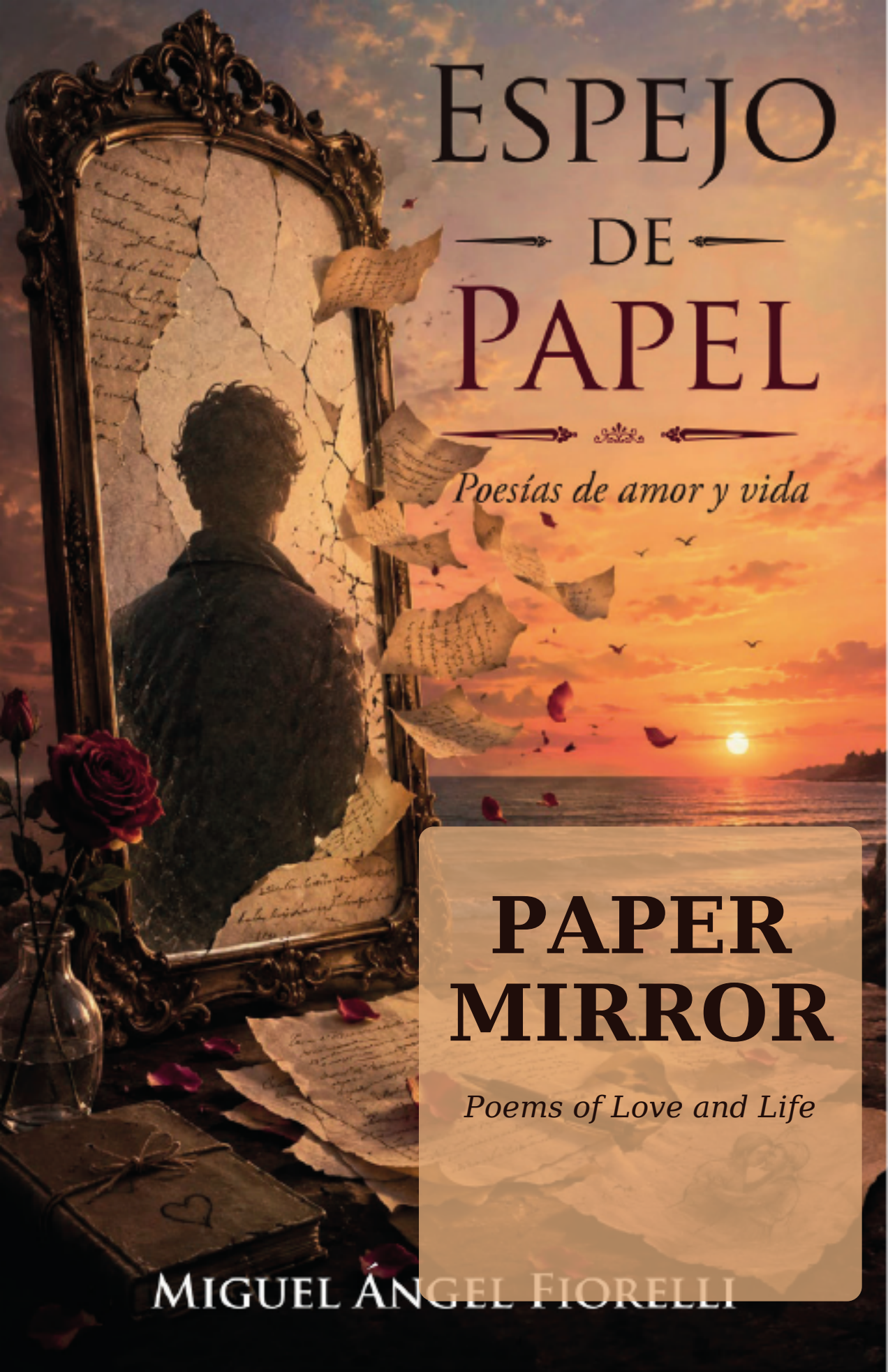

Espejo
de
Papel
Poesías de amor y vida
PAPER
MIRROR
Poems of Love and Life
Miguel Ángel Fiorelli

THE AUTHOR

I was born in Mar del Plata, an emblematic city on the Atlantic coast of the Province of Buenos Aires, Argentina, on July 20, 1952.

That same day, seventeen years later, I received what may have been my greatest gifts: on July 20, 1969, humankind reached the Moon, and my birthday became celebrated in Argentina as Friendship Day. My biotechnological academic background and my humanistic view of life could hardly have found more meaningful symbols.

I am grateful to life - the same life that so many times threatened to leave me out on the street or saying goodbye from a hospital bed - for allowing me to reach this moment and publish Paper Mirror, with the intimate hope that some of my poetic traces may awaken the poet of lived lives that we all carry within us.

Thank you for allowing me into your lives.

Miguel Ángel Fiorelli

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ABSENCE TAKES UP SPACE

LOVE

Love is an endless poem,
written by two, together, shared.
It has parentheses, pauses,
question marks...

And perhaps, someday,
for one it becomes a new paragraph,
while for the other, an ellipsis
that will never end...

AT THE CENTRAL POST OFFICE

At your poste restante,
our love letters,
the ones we secretly sent…

Today I know that nothing
has ever equaled you;
through your veins of paper
flowed my love and my tears.

IT RAINS

Today it rains, and I miss
your waist beneath my hands,
the steaming coffee,
the burning logs,
that kiss, those tears,
the full moon lighting your face,
the sheets, our accomplices,
and the elves keeping watch.

Today it rains and you are gone…
only me
and your ghost lingering near.

TRACE OF LOVE

What is the bed of a dried-up river
if not the memory of the water
that once shaped it?

My heart is that riverbed...
your love, the emptiness
that gave it shape.

YOU WERE

You were my pause,
you were my peace,
you were my longing,
you were living once again,
you were my courage to change,
you were my only love...

But in the end
you were only an illusion
and a need.

YOUR DEPARTURE

Your absence takes up space,
it fills the entire place
you once knew how to conquer,
plus that great extra space
I made for you in silence,
in secret,
with the intimate hope
that you would never leave.

And yes... today your absence
completely fills
my entire world.

AT EVERY FUNERAL

At every funeral
there is always someone
who will soon die...

Some from grief,
others from sadness,
or helplessness,
or worst of all: loneliness.

But there will also be someone
who will die of love while still alive.

Just like that... nothing more...

Because there are loves
that are simply impossible
to carry alone.

SEPARATION

I look at my home one last time,
corners filled with history,
furniture emptied of photographs,
an immense bed,
with sheets stained
by lonely awakenings
even when you were beside me.

If everything remained so untouched,
it was because it was never used,
just as my body is now so empty
because you never desired it...

QUEBRACHO AND CHARCOAL

That was you and me
when the fire of love
set us both ablaze,
and to keep its glow alive
consumed us differently.

For although both give light and warmth,
quebracho and charcoal
come from different trees
and carry different histories.

Of quebracho and charcoal -
that, too, was the story
of my love
and yours.

MY PEN AND YOU

I created you there,
in every desperate poem,
in every story of a life worn thin,
in every fear and every emptiness...

You... who still live in every line
of my aging skin,
in every innocence you violated...

You... who appear before me
naked... sensual... defiant...
and fatally devilish.

Why do you appear only now,
when there is nothing left of me?

Or rather...
nothing at all!

BY THE SEA

I loved you for a lifetime,
and on that damned day
much... much more.

I DECIDED TO GO ON

I gave her my best days,
which I traded for her best nights.

I gave her my passions, I gave her my song,
I showed her my innocence and my tears.

Then I surrendered to silence
and to the fear of never finding her again,
to the loneliness that, without her,
was killing me in bottles at the bar...

Today I gathered up my broken pieces
and swore I would put myself back together.

For she gave me only her body,
never anything, anything at all
of everything else...

WHAT I DIDN'T TELL HER

International airport,
storm and night,
my fears, like a gag,
keep me from saying...

Don't go,
I couldn't,
I wouldn't know how,
I wouldn't have,
I wouldn't be...

But she left.

And then she could,
and then she knew,
and then she wanted,
and then she had,
and then she became...

And I am still here,
without her love,
alone, silent and mute,
in the very same place...

WHEN LOVE ARRIVES, DOES IT EVER LEAVE?

It was so long ago, yet to me it is still today.

Her face, now lined with age,
that I once found soft as velvet;
her mouth, so tender and so wild when kissing,
a dazzling woman and a little girl in intimacy.

I feel her heartbeat
through our intertwined hands.

She never wanted to leave,
she only asked for one more day,
but the damned machine displays the final image:
just a single line... continuous and fatal...

They carry away her ebony body,
naked beneath the hospital white.

Today my beloved lives throughout my being,
from that... my most special place,
where my blood enters from one side
and from the other, always, as always,
flows away.

NO MORE

I've run out of I love yous,
of I love you and I feel you,
of I'll wait for you and I'm here,
of I'll give to you and give to me,
of I need you and need me,
of I'll hold you and hold me,
of I'll help you and help me,
of inside me and inside you,
of in you and in me,
of I'll look for you and look for me,
of I'll call you and call me,
of come to me and I'll come to you.

I can no longer find the caresses
you gave me and I kept,
I no longer have a you loved me,
not even an I love you.

I have no more kisses -
you took the last one with you.

You're no longer in my life,
and I no longer live within myself...

I COULD NEVER FORGET YOU...

Because I'm no longer the man
who had never known you,
the man who always knew
they were only loves created
in borrowed emptiness...

Why could I never forget you?

Because this love is already
all over my skin,
tattooed there in ink and kisses.

It simply lives within me now,
as though there had never been a past,
because for the first time
I felt completely desired.

Why can I no longer forget you?

Because the wheel cannot be uninvented,
nor can I give my skin to another,
pretending that you're still here.

SLOW DOWN... HEART, SLOW DOWN

When I tried to set my heart to the right time,
I discovered it was thirty, a hundred years behind,
depending on the occasion.

I forced it into the present
to live the loves of today,
but it was already too broken,
with no thread left to mend it.

My skin, more sensitive now,
no longer recognized it,
and my mind could no longer bear
so much pain.

So I placed it in my forgotten chest,
where the pure loves of long ago are kept,
wrapped in paper letters scented with orange blossom,
written in blood-red ink
of passion and desire.

Right there, where ladies live by day,
but become free women
in the nights of love...

Today my mind breathes easier,
free from hearts it must protect,

and my weary heart now rests
a hundred years in the past,

waiting, perhaps, for "her"
to emerge from one of my poems
and come rescue it...
so together they may fly.

My heart waits for her,
for it can no longer go out
and search for her.

TOGETHER WE KEEP EACH OTHER WARM

ONCE... NEVER AGAIN

Last night I held in my hands
a perfectly tuned instrument.

Kisses, caresses and embraces
created a world of dreams;

music, people dancing,
and that secluded place
where your fiery eyes
melted away my past.

REBIRTH

Who would have thought
that on that afternoon
you would feel so deeply
and tears would begin to flow.

Who would have thought
that love could
transform your body
so you could know yourself
as a woman.

A LOVE HAIKU

Love is being
free to kiss you,
and you free to kiss me.

WHICH WAS STRONGER?

Your heart or my blood,
your skin or my touch,
your sweat or my thirst,
your beauty or my eyes,
your jungle or my wildness,
your cries or my silences,
your curves or my light,
your desires or mine,
your river or my riverbed,
your goals or my roads,
your fire or my logs...

Which was stronger,
life or Genesis,
that you should live
and that we should love each other
so deeply!

A METAPHORICAL LOVE

Dawn breaks upon a dreamlike beach,
the rising sun bathes me in light,
my bare feet carve into the sand
the hieroglyphics of my solitary steps.

Beyond the waves, like a dancing mermaid,
the horizon sketches the curve of the Earth,
while around an intelligent cloud
a ballet of graceful seagulls
turns the sky into its natural stage.

Suddenly, a ray of beauty
enters my mind through my melting eyes:

she and her board,
a sensual, perfect pair,
surfing the waters
straight toward my very core.

Together we walked the crystalline shore.
Then I looked behind
and saw only my footprints,
a testimony etched into the sand
of our wedding walk...

Could it be that she remained within me,

somewhere between my DNA
and my sexuality?

TIMES LEFT BEHIND

My trembling hands open
the secret little shoebox
lined with tissue paper,
guardian of beloved memories.

Her perfumed letters, the tin ring,
the neckerchief still scented with roses,
the striped shirt of her neighborhood club,
candy wrappers from sweets we shared,
glittering cards and postage stamps
on letters carrying our love.

Yesterday, a friend told me
that Paris still delights
in her bare feet...

Could it be that she, too, still keeps,
somewhere private,
our diary stained
on that afternoon
of unbridled love?

A CHANCE DAY

Me, sitting at a cafe table,
giving my thoughts a rest, alone.

Longing to feel myself, to find myself
in the peace of a rural town,
so distant, so lonely,
and yet so much the same.

And then you walked in... as if you had appeared from nowhere,
your green eyes, your untamed complexion,
simple and fatal!

I prayed you wouldn't look at me,
because your eyes would carry me away.

But you looked at me...

My table was left empty,
you still drinking there at the bar,
and I with you,
deep within your loneliness.

TODAY, YOU BY MY SIDE

The horizon has always captivated me,
with its sea in constant motion.

The moon, its phases, its light,
and its rising over my native sea.

The eternal illusion of a "see you tomorrow"
and the reality of the night that comes before it.

The love we dream of...
and the love we build piece by piece.

Everything so unreachable
and so fleeting...

Today, in your eyes and in your hands,
I find the horizon, the moon and peace,

and in every "see you tomorrow"
in which you are always there,
I find the magic
of a love that is real.

SHE CAME FROM WITHIN

She came into my life
the way those we no longer seek arrive,
yet they are the very ones
we so deeply desire.

She came the way only good things come...
from within!

And she took possession
of my soul and my body.

She came forever...
to die loving,
always too late
and always too soon,

to begin again...
to live life fully.

IT'S JUST THAT I NEED YOU SO MUCH...

Yesterday I saw you on a poster,
and a few days ago
you were living in a movie...

I imagined you a thousand times
on that street corner,
or sitting at a cafe table, book in hand,
or on the sand or in the grass,
barefoot and free,
as though searching for me...

If I invented you,
if you are merely a desire of mine
fulfilled in a thousand poems,

then... wait for me
on the final line,
and let us go on together
with no more blank pages.

But if you are real...

if you once looked at me
and I lost myself in your humanity,
then you already know

how to find me.

And if you still desire me
as much as I desire you,

then come, don't wait -
time is running short,

and there is still so much
untouched skin left for us
to fill with poems and kisses.

ONE BY ONE... TWO BY TWO

Two by two... I tell myself no,
two by two... perhaps it should once again be no.

But I only want you to remember
that one by one... they broke us both,
that one by one... no one ever cared for us,
that one by one... others only used us.

We both know that this time,
together we are everything
we once wanted
for the two of us.

ONLY YOU

Something of a girl,
so much of a woman,
captive beauty
longing to be,

your eyes that hold
everything they see -

if they should ever look at me,
I will disappear...

DAWN

A drop of dew
flooded my chest with emotion,
a new day was being born
and in your arms
I awakened.

I NEVER ASKED FOR ANYTHING

I never asked life for anything,
because I always knew
it would give me nothing.

And yet, as the years went by,
I found a few - very few - treasures
that life had hidden away for me,
until I could unearth them
with my own hands...

The most beautiful treasure I ever found
bore, written in my own blood,
only your name -

and no one else's...

WHAT IF IT HAPPENS TO US?

If we kiss for the first time,
how do we unkiss?

If a great love is born between us,
how do we unlove?

Because...
if we come to know each other,
if we breathe in each other's scent,
if we touch each other,
if we give each other pleasure,
how could we ever forget?

I ask you
because I already love you.

THE "JUST FOR TODAY" ONES

Just for today I won't drink...
but I'm still an alcoholic.

Just for today I won't use...
but I'm still an addict.

And you tell me...
just for today I'll care for you,
just for today I'll cherish you,
just for today I'll love you -

and tomorrow... you won't?

Because if I'm alive tomorrow,
I'll need you by my side.

NO ONE EVER KNEW

The ladies in the neighborhood
whisper softly
about our secret love.

I WRITE TO YOU, RESPECTFULLY

If you have forgotten me,
or I no longer matter to you,
or you need to forget me,
or perhaps, just perhaps,
you might still love me,

then simply let me know,
with only two words...

But don't ask me
to write you an entire book
just to tell you
how much I still miss you...

WITH YOU

Perhaps two loves
can coexist within one heart,

but in mine
the ghost of another
could never exist.

I SIMPLY...

I cannot ask you for anything:
not to love me, nor to care for me,
not to kiss me, nor to desire me,
not even to miss me...

Because in the love I want,
loving, caring, kissing, desiring...
are true acts of magic,

and not asking for them
is the trick.

I don't need people who merely give;
I simply need
your magic...

INTIMATE

What if the world doesn't know?
What does it matter!

What if they say ours is in vain?
How absurd!

US

Us,
who care for each other
when caring is what we need.

Who keep each other warm
when the cold comes from long ago.

Who deny ourselves
when denying ourselves
is our way of saying yes.

Us,
who, choosing not to give ourselves,
still give ourselves...

why pretend to keep searching
when we have already found each other!

WHAT IF SOMEDAY

What if someday
we could believe
that the sky may cloud over
and yet it won't rain.

What if someday
we could understand
that we know nothing
and then begin to learn.

What if someday
we could hold
an empty glass
and still quench our thirst.

What if someday
I could hold you,
woman, in my arms
and together we could grow.

LONELY HEARTS

SIMPLY HER

She knows nothing of miracles;
in her life, everything is urgent.

Survival is the priority,
and dying is a never-ever.

For she never learned the verb to lose:
neither the cold of weather
nor the cold of the soul,
nor tables empty of food,
nor months impossible to pay,
nor rain upon her muddy streets,
nor failures at work,
nor failures of loveless love,
nor family reproaches,
nor her own reproaches
for not understanding.

Whenever something good disappeared,
there were no tears in her eyes.

She never granted anything
the power to defeat her.

For her, a little is always a lot,
and too much is impossible to understand.

At the end of every day
she immerses herself in cheap soap operas,
perhaps imagining herself in other lives,

those in which sometimes...
only sometimes...
her prince appears.

HOLIDAYS?

Oh, those holidays,
social days and family days,
of children, fathers, mothers,
uncles, aunts and grandparents,
present or dead in memory;

Valentine's Days and Christmases -

somehow, no matter how,
no matter with whom,
whether from truth or convenience,
they are always days for gathering,
remembering or giving gifts.

But there should also be
a day for the forgotten,
for those without homes or embraces,
for those for whom later will be too late,
for the unloved and abandoned,
for those for whom it never was good
and never will be.

Could it be that oblivion and indifference
have no gifts to buy?

Or perhaps sadness and abandonment,

loneliness and helplessness,
will never have a date
on such a hypocritical calendar.

SHE DIED IN MY ARMS

Night falls in Boston,
eighteen degrees below zero,
and a snowstorm
so common around here.

Hot coffee and an honest conversation with Sharon,
my chance companion at the counter
of an empty bar.

Two strangers,
yet somehow lifelong companions at once...

I spoke of my work,
she of her advanced music studies,
our broken dreams and sorrowful awakenings,
her artist's hands, her dark complexion, her green eyes,
and my wrinkles and my hands
warmed around a cup of coffee.

A break in the storm
after three unforgettable hours together,
and a formal "farewell forever"...

Suddenly, a crash -
shattered glass everywhere...

A drunk driver, losing control in the snow,
plows into the bar.

She took the full, fatal impact
and fell into my arms,
looking at me... smiling...
her hands clasped tightly in mine,
as though she already knew the end...

They say she died instantly...

but twenty-eight years have passed
and she is still alive within me.

Because sometimes life leaves us alive
inside someone else...
who knows in whom.

URBAN WINTER

Pedestrian sidewalk,
indifference passing by.

Three days ago Pedro
died of natural causes...

IT WASN'T JUST ANOTHER DAY

It wasn't just another day...
it was a day and more... much more...

A weightless silence
took possession of her entire being.

Everything became eternally slow,
and she would never forget that instant.

A deadly traveling bullet
changed her life... for nothing at all.

She, his beloved,
still tells this story
fifty-two years later...

Because he remained in her life
like a memory
that never goes away.

A CYBER LOVE

Juan and Lucia had an "online" love.

For two hundred and sixty-nine days
there was passion, mystery and truth.

On the screen she showed him
her finest images:
a sculpted body,
her strawberry lips,
her sexuality and much more.

Juan showed her his soul,
his virginity,
his passions reinvented,
his tenderness and his peace.

Juan taught her the verb to love,
desire and dreaming,
and almost... almost...
how to breathe as well.

Lucia felt life...
something impossible
in her reality.

On day two hundred and seventy,
still paraplegic,
Juan could no longer awaken.

And she, Lucia,
the virtual computer,
could no longer remain "online"
without Juan.

Her most intimate chips
began to fail.

Lucia died on purpose;
she simply allowed herself
to shut down...

Because no one had programmed her
for so much loneliness.

WINTER DAYS

Winter days
with the same old cold,
when the air feels
more like air,

and coats conceal
lonely hearts...

In some bar along life's way,
behind a cup of hot coffee,
or between the pages of a book,

someone pretends not to be alone,
glancing sideways,
hoping that someone else
is about to walk in...

REALITY

Empty cradles
of absent parents,

stacked coffins
from present-day bombs.

UNIONS THAT HEAL

November second
in my hometown.

Women dressed in black
and children who don't understand,
couples without their partners,
friends without their friendships,
people arriving... people leaving.

It is a holiday
in the home of burial niches.

Today, all the dead
live one more day...

HER DAY HAS COME

On the night she dreamed of,
everything is new... so strange.

She knew nothing of love,
only of giving birth.

For this, her night,
a tight black dress,
radiance and beauty
upon her tiny sculpted body,

makeup on the outside,
her black hair wet,
blush upon her cheeks
and her legs trembling...

The die was cast,
heads or tails was the game,
the coin was already
spinning in the air.

The new day found her different,
as though floating...

In her same old mirror

she barely recognized herself.

For her beauty was no longer
only on the outside,
but now within her as well.

A red rose in her hands,
stolen at dawn
as she left the room,

her only witness,
an accomplice telling her
she had not been dreaming.

Because that night, at last,
love had made her drunk...

YEARS LATER...

She was born thirty years later,
and love united them
like passionate teenagers.

When he was already old,
suddenly he left far too soon...

She caresses her belly
and looks toward the sky, crying.

For her, he never truly left -
he remained within her womb,
cloning himself...

A LOVE LIVED

They had no before,
nor would there be an after.

There was never a "forever,"
nor did they accept a "never."

Each encounter was a photograph,
and there were so many kisses
that their love
could already have been filmed.

He gave her his past,
and she...
one more life.

WITH THE DREAMS OF LONG AGO

RETURNING

A colony of tiny mosses,
graffiti of abandonment;
my entire childhood
in a single mural.

MY NEIGHBORHOOD

A tree for a swing,
a target for our knives,
summer shade,
a climbing gym,
a little house high above...

An empty lot, soccer without goals,
a track for handmade toy cars,
holes for our marble games, worn-out fingers,
and that secret cave, accomplice
to our earliest loves.

Yesterday I returned
with the dreams of long ago,
but nothing of mine
remained in that neighborhood.

MY BREAKING POINTS

They erase me,
they question me,
they bleed me dry.

Then,
like plants,
from every break
a new shoot of me is born.

OH, THINGS...

Nothing creates them,
nothing destroys them,
everything transforms them.

I, on the other hand, was created,
and I only transform myself,
and alone I shall die.

ABSENCES

They left us suddenly
and filled us with emptiness.

Could it be that our dead
want us to go on living?

DECISION

Before me, two roads,
both straight,
both seemingly the same.

But I chose the one
that later left me
much... much farther behind.

WHAT?

What must I understand
that I do not understand?

What must I know
that I do not know?

What must I not feel
even though I feel it?

What is this thing
of crying,
alone, so terribly alone,
and waiting...?

MY SILENCES

Cries from a past...
from those who are no longer here,
from those who were never there
though they could have been,
from those who were there
and grew tired of staying,

from loves exhausted
by so much waiting,
from unions without knots or bows,
from bonds worn out without ever being used,

from other people's dreams
I never learned how to carry,
and from dreams of my own
that I will never fulfill.

MY NOW

A new country,
my forced exile.

Eating and surviving
on odd jobs,
my only goal.

The steam from the iron
enters my senses,
passes through my memories,

and I become one
with those suits
belonging to unknown characters
who lent them to me
through my work.

MY DEATH

I am the death
of your beloved cat Merlin,
and in my mind I relive
his last, ninth life with us.

He still appears sometimes
in some passing feline
that looks at me, licks me,
and moves me.

As a teenager,
overflowing with fear and loneliness,
I was visited by the death
of my first girlfriend,

and she remained, ethereal,
in my hand and in my pen,
inspiring every poem
of absent love.

I will never know my own death,
but I know she has lived within me
since the day I was born.

She knows me better
than I know myself.

Perhaps that is why,
on that nearly fatal day,
she refused to appear,
so as not to destroy
my deepest unfulfilled dream.

She will come only
after my final heartbeat,
to visit, from time to time,
the hearts of those
I love most.

But to you, my sweet love,
she will come only
when necessary,

to replace your sadness
with the kisses we once lived,

and so you will always know
that you are no longer alone,

because she knows
that I stayed behind
to live with you...

WHAT ARE WE?

We are unique beings
with no replacements.

We were born by chance
carrying the whole human race
behind us.

We are made only
from what was available;
we were put together
with love or abandonment.

We reinvent ourselves
a thousand times to survive,
to improve
or simply to endure.

We care or destroy,
we create or break,
we desire and are desired,
to care for
or to enslave.

We understand reality
or invent one of our own.

And some of us - very few -
one day fall in love,

and everything resets,

and we no longer care
if this
is our ending.

NO ONE MOURNED HIM

Balmaceda Bridge,
shelter for the homeless,
companions in life
and endless loneliness...

It was Saturday night,
a night of abuse and more...

With determined steps
he came toward me,
the man who had already
abused me once before.

He exposed himself
and I drew my knife.

The police asked no questions
and his disgusting body
was taken away.

From that Saturday on,
we all stopped praying.

FABER CASTELL

I was born in the little town
of Pencil and Paper,
founded by the Germans
Faber Castell.

There I met my best friend,
black Faber HB.

My neighborhood was very poor,
made of used sheets of paper,
broken pencils, worn-out erasers...

And love letters written
on newspaper,
in that secret place
that served as our neighborhood post office.

As children, on rainless Sundays,
during the afternoon siesta,
we would go to Canson Square,

to spend a day in color
at the Caran d'Ache circus
and, sitting happily on the ground,
paint our dreams
drawn in black and white.

There I met my first love,
Black Ink,
whom everyone affectionately called
"the Chinese girl"
because of her unmistakable features.

She gave life to my life,
and I gave life to her stains,
which, like magical strokes,
she tattooed upon my hands.

Now, already old,
I live in a techno-neighborhood,
a land of algorithms
invented by the system,

where neither privacy
nor freedom exists,
and we are all ghosts
aboard the same ship.

Today I urgently need you,
my beloved India ink.

I urgently, desperately need you

to tattoo my hands again,

but in this techno-neighborhood
love has been encrypted.

GEO HAIKU

Water arriving,
nature in all its fullness,
the grass rejoices.

ODE TO MY REAPER

Already on my way,
my soul laid bare,
my feet bare from so much walking.

Perhaps no time remains
to begin again,

empty of everything,
flooded with nothing,

with no stories in the present
and no future left to create,

alone with myself
in these, my final steps,
though even today I do not know
how many more there will be...

I will reset my mind,
care for my body,
heal my soul,

and use my remaining hours
to learn how to love you.

You already know...
as though there were no tomorrow!

So that at the end of the road,
there... right there...

I want only you
to be beside me,

you...
my finest Angel
for the end.

MY BELOVED OBJECTS

They are the objects of my life,
preserved through time,

icons of moments
unlike any others,

witnesses to the changes
between who I was
and who I would later
reinvent myself to be...

Or simply tunnels through time
through which that lonely child
comes alive again,

kite, cane and paper in hand,
sailing through space,
taming the wind,

which for me...
was freedom!

Or the amulets
hanging from my chest,

which, on my darkest nights,
whispered to my devastated soul:

when dawn comes...
you will live!

ODE TO THE FORGOTTEN

Surely everyone
has forgotten me by now,

but I have not yet
forgotten myself.

I still see my children being born,
though now I know nothing of them...

And I remember you too, woman,
loving you,

even though you are dead...
today, just as on the first day...

Love also returns me
to my school,

to mornings without breakfast
but filled with the desire to learn,

and afternoons gathering cardboard
so I could later eat.

I was also very happy
working honestly,

forty-two years
as a public servant,

saving lives
and being reborn
with every life I saved.

Today, "Happy New Year"
can be heard everywhere.

It is far too cold
and the snow will not stop falling.

I will shelter beneath
the government bridge,

alongside other survivors,
good people too,

all victims
of human cruelty.

Tonight it will be hard to sleep...
fear, cold, hunger and thirst.

If I do not wake tomorrow,
someone will find me,

and surely it will be someone
who still knows nothing
of abandonment,

who has never known hunger,
nor such bitter cold,
nor so little faith...

ODE TO MY SOLITUDE

My solitude...
I search for you
and you are no longer here.

They say they have seen you...
some more, some less,

entangled in my own social networks,
in lonely bars that charge for searching,

in families that make me believe
they need me,

in other people's gatherings
where they tell me I must be,

or healing broken hearts
that, once healed,
leave forever...
without saying goodbye.

And also, more often than not,
among bodies without souls,

like a captive slave
to their toxic love.

Oh, my Solitude...
we urgently need
to find each other again!

I wait for you
in our safe place,

beneath the moon and stars,
facing the sea...

Do not take too long,
I beg you.

Only you are my identity.

I do not want to end my days
like a puzzle taken apart,
scattered among others.

WHO WOULD I BE WITHOUT WORDS?

Would I still be
the one I was on the day I was born?

Or the one I was shortly before,
when the world spoke to me
while nature was creating me?

Without words,
I would be a living being
in a body made only of instincts
and a little more.

Yet I would be something.
Something, surely.

But today I speak and write,

and because I write,
I write to you,

and because I write to you,
I tell you...

Knowing that without your love
and your eroticism,

built through fearless words
and through the language
of body and gaze,

my life would be nothing
but lovelessness and ignorance.

And so I tell you
and I tell myself...

that without words,
the primitive being
would return within me,

with nothing...
absolutely nothing...
inside me.

ABSENT MOTHER

Why couldn't you caress my forehead
even when I had no fever?

Why did you never hear
the child within me crying?

Why didn't your hands touch me
when I was there beside you?

Oh, Mother!

I know you don't understand
what I'm talking about,
nor why I searched
for your hands
in so many women.

And today I don't understand either
why I am here,
kneeling at your grave
and crying.

BLANK PAGE

Blank page, you look at me,
defiant, aggressive,

waiting for me to write something,
very little, but something,

something that will scream
the silence
my hands are keeping quiet.

But you and I both know,
blank page, my blank page,

that we are both longing
for that someone to come to me
and bring love
to my alphabet...

OH, THE KISSES...

Kisses that care,
kisses that cherish,
kisses that listen,
kisses that speak,
kisses that understand,
kisses that move us,
kisses that protect,
kisses for a child yet to be born...

And also
the kiss of an ending,
the kiss that kills,
the kiss that separates,
the kiss that betrays,
the kiss that never existed,
the kiss that never was...

All those kisses
my lips have kissed.

WOODEN HORSE

Wooden horse
from the carousel of dreams,
carry me at a gallop
across plains and steppes.

Wooden horse,
even if there is no brass ring,
I will stay with you,
riding upon your being.

Wooden horse,
your sap has not died;
through your veins still flows
the love of the craftsman
who brought you to life.

Today it rains
and we are alone,
going round and round,

with no children to watch us,

only me
and your wood
from the tree
you once were.

SHE... THE GREATER PART OF ME

She surrounds me
and contains me,
thirsting for water and pleasure.

Violated time and again
by surgeries in operating rooms
and all that came after,

each scar a cry,
and every cry
a that's over now.

Untouched by perfumes at dawn,
no one remained with her
after pleasure,

for fear of forever,
which happens only once.

The sun makes her blush,
my heart lulls her to sleep.

She is my map.

She is my skin...

TRACES

I look at my hands
and at my entire body,

which before long
will decompose into matter.

It endured too much
from the whims of my mind,

and even left descendants
in lives that could never
choose me,

but which, because of me,
are lives
and will remain so...

My mind will switch off
in a brief instant,

as brief as that instant
of birth.

Having lived leaves traces,

in people who may simply
erase them:

superficial traces
of kisses, embraces, conversations,

and those of favors
I gave in solitude.

But above all,
my deepest traces,

the imprints
of mistakes I never intended,

which today, surely,
have become painful scars
in others...

WHAT I STILL HAVEN'T TOLD MYSELF

That my body
is no longer the same,

that the accident
changed my destiny,

that your skin
no longer remembers me,

that our love
was mine alone,

that your betrayal...
was betrayal,

that my daughters
have grown,

that the work I love
is no longer mine,

that my childhood home
has been sold,

that my neighborhood
no longer belongs with me,

that I dwell in exile...
but I do not live,

that I no longer choose
those who did not choose me,

that your absence
cannot be filled with presences,

that my past
is not my destiny,

that I am still alive
even though defeated...

It's just that I don't know
how to bury so many dead
that life keeps leaving
so deep inside me...

I WAS NEVER AFRAID

I was never afraid to live,
much less to die.

Life and death
are two faces
of my own existence...

The one I do fear,
and deeply,
is myself,

because when those special moments come,
I never know
what I might do with myself,
or how far I might go...

SCREAMED SILENCES

Of those who are no longer here,
of those who never were,

of those who grew tired of staying,
of those who could have stayed
but didn't,

of loves weary of wandering,
of loves never used,

of other people's dreams
and of my own,

impossible
to scream...

JUST A LITTLE

At the end of my days,
my life was only a little:

a little time remaining,

a little of that love
that never arrives,

a little peace
that never lasts,

a little courage
when nothing remains,

a little of nature
already waiting
for my return,

a little of you
with me,

a little of me
living in everyone,

a little of everyone
in every little part of me,

a little reality
of a world without me,

a little magic
in the trick
of not wanting to know.

A little of everything...

just a little.

That was all.

PAPER MIRROR

MIGUEL ÁNGEL FIORELLI



We are our steps,

we will be our traces...

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